The Old Turtle and the Broken Truth

By Douglas Wood

Inscription: To all who seek truths and who listen to the language of breezes. (And turtles.)

Once, in a beautiful, far away land…where every stone was a teacher and every breeze a language, where every lake was a mirror and every tree a ladder to the stars, into this far and lovely land there fell…a truth.

It streaked down from the stars, trailing a tail as long as the sky. But as it fell, it broke.

One of the pieces blazed off through the night sky, and the other fell to earth, Crow found the fallen piece. It seemed to be a sort of stone. He picked it up.

"This is a lovely truth," said crow. "I will keep it." But after he had held it for awhile. "This truth does not feel quite right. A part of it is missing. I will look for a whole one." He flew off and dropped it to the ground.

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INTRODUCTION

To all who seek truths and who listen to the language of the breezes . . . . author Douglas Wood expresses a desire for our collective conscience. He gently proposes a world where tranquility is dependent on mutual understanding. A healed world can come from acceptance. The Old Turtle and the Broken Truth by Douglas Wood.

Butterfly and Bear discovered the truth, drawn by its sweetness. But each found that it left a bitter taste after all. "There is something missing in this truth." And they left it alone.

Then a human being found it.

He was walking slowly, listening to breezes, gazing at beauties above and below and all around him, when he found the broken truth. On it was writing, and the writing said: "YOU ARE LOVED."

The man held it carefully, thinking it was the loveliest thing he had ever seen.

The man took the wonderful truth to his people --- those who lived with him, who spoke as he spoke and dressed as he dressed and whose faces looked like his.

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And together they cherished their newfound truth and believed in it.

After a while, the man and his people did not hear the language of breezes and stones anymore, but heard only their truth. And for them, it was enough.

And they called it…The Truth.

The Truth made the people feel good and proud and strong. But soon they also began to feel fear and even anger toward those who were not like themselves.

Time passed, and *other* people said, "We must have this Great Truth for ourselves, for with it comes happiness and power."

Many battles were fought, and the broken truth was won and lost, won and lost, over and over again.

The stones and trees suffered. The breezes and waters suffered, and the animals, and the earth….and most of all, the people suffered.

Finally, the animals went to Old Turtle --- ancient and wise as the mountains and seas themselves.

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"This truth the people quarrel over," they said, "It is broken and does not work. Please tell the people."

"I am sorry," answered Old Turtle, "but the people will not listen. They are not yet ready."

And the suffering continued.
Until one day…a Little Girl came to find Old Turtle. She had crossed the Mountains of Imagining and the River of Wondering Why, she had found her way through the Forest of Finding Out. And when she had grown tired, she had ridden on the backs of animals or the wings of birds, and they helped her find her way.

When she saw Old Turtle, she could hardly speak.

"Why have you come so far to find me, Little One?" asked Old Turtle. Her voice rumbled like far away thunder, but was soft as the breeze through a caterpillar's whiskers.

The Little Girl <said>. "Where I live, the earth is sore, and people are suffering. Battles are fought, over and over again. People say it has always been this way and will never change. Can it change, Old Turtle?

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Old Turtle spoke. "The world you describe is not the world that has always been, Little One."

Then Old Turtle told of how the people had found the broken truth, and the suffering it caused.

"It is because it is so close to a great, whole truth that is has such beauty, and that the people love it so," said Old Turtle. "It is the lost portion of the broken truth that the people need, if the world is to be made whole again."

Asked the Little Girl. "Can we put the truth back together again?"

"First, my child," said Old Turtle, "remember that there are truths all around us, and within us. They twinkle in the night sky and bloom upon the earth. They fall upon us every day, silent as the snow and gentle as the rain. The people, clutching their one truth, forget that it is a part of all the small and lovely truths of life.

For a long time then the two friends were quiet, high on their hill in the very center of the world.

Finally, the Little Girl asked one more question. "Old Turtle how will the people learn these things?"

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"By listening once more to the languages of breezes, by learning lessons from stones and animals and trees and stars. Even turtles," she chuckled, "and little girls.

It is time for you to go, to return to your people and tell them what you have learned, and to help them mend their Broken Truth.

"Take this with you," said Old Turtle, as she placed something in the Little Girl's hand. "I have saved it for a very long time, for someone just like you."

The Little Girl looked: It was a kind of stone, a mysterious, beautiful stone. It was lovely to touch, and it made her feel good to hold it.

"Thank you, Old Turtle," And then she started home.

Once more Crow led the way, and again when the Little Girl grew tired, all her animal friends helped. She sometimes touched the stone Old Turtle had given her to renew her strength. And it took a long time yet almost no time at all…

But it had been a very long journey, and those who take great journeys of the heart are changed.

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The people did not recognize her. And when she spoke, they did not understand. She spoke of a world made of small and gentle truths, of all the peoples being one People. But they could not catch her meaning.

Finally, Crow, flew to the place high above the village where the Great Truth was kept. He cawed in his loudest voice. The Little Girl knew what to do. She climbed to the high place herself. She took Old Turtle's stone from her pocket and…carefully…added the missing piece to the old, broken one.

The fit was perfect.

"YOU ARE LOVED . . . AND SO ARE THEY."

Some smiled.

And some cried.

And they began to understand.

Time passed and upon the beautiful land the trees climbed like ladders to the stars, the waters shone like mirrors, and the people saw their beauty. A breeze stirred and they heard its music. Tiny truths fell by day

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and night, and the people found them and kept them in their hearts.

And slowly, as the people met other people different from themselves, they began to see…themselves.

And far away, on a hill in the very center of the world…Old Turtle smiled.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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